Second—and this perhaps seems clearer in retrospect than when I was researching the book—the narrative treatment of Ashoka's life needed to be extended to his ideas as they developed over the long years of his reign. Despite the fact that Ashoka has been an extraordinarily rich subject of study, his shifting mental horizons, as expressed in the public arena of his epigraphs, remain insufficiently studied. The Ashoka of the relatively short First Rock Edict, as I saw it, was an impatient confessor of his metamorphosis as a Buddhist. Several years later, as he spoke at greater length in messages engraved on other rocks and pillars, he appeared an altogether different kind of speaker. So, seeing his ideas unfold over time is crucial to this story of Ashoka, especially since much of it concerns his trajectory as a communicator. His changing ideas as expressed in his edicts, I might add, make him appear as a real human being changing over time. I attempt to delineate his intellectual evolution through a chronological teasing out of his thoughts and emotions from the texts in which he chooses to speak of his life and calling.

Finally, the Ashoka that I write of is very much a product of the places in which he engraved his messages. This explains why this book is called *Ashoka in Ancient India*. The title points to the fact that the archaeological and locational dimensions of specific places are crucial to my understanding of the messages and their author. My journey of discovery took me to many of Ashoka's edicts and monuments: outside India to the terai region of Nepal, within the country to Bihar, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, and Odisha. Scrambling across rocks and up steep inclines, walking through forests of unforgettable grandeur and beauty, stumbling upon his epigraphs in the middle of modern colonies and museums, getting tantalizing glimpses of relict structures and vanished waterbodies in the vicinity of the places where the words of the emperor can still be seen, all these gave me a first-hand feel of what generations of archaeologists had found. Such landscapes